

New Applications of Jakobson’s “Broad Metrics”: Sung Poetry and Dual-Metered Verse

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Abstract. This article extends Roman Jakobson’s framework of “broad metrics” to sung poetry. Building on his dichotomies of verse design/instance (poetic meter and rhythm) and delivery design/instance (recitation rules and performance), it proposes an additional dyad: musical design/instance (musical meter and rhythm), which often diverge from verse patterns. The study also incorporates Mihhail Lotman’s concept of secondary meter to account for dual metricity in verse. Analysis of sung texts with dual-metered verse structures – such as but not limited to hyperpaeonic syllabotonic meters – shows how verse and music coalesce to shape delivery rhythms that may oscillate between multiple meters. Whenever this occurs, the choice of a particular rhythmic variant is conditioned by the delivery design (performance strategy). The model is substantiated by case studies of three Soviet-era songs.

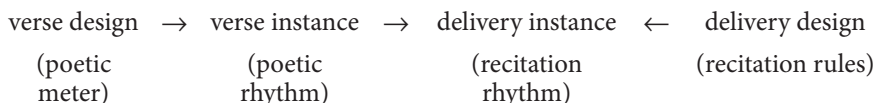
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Introduction

In his seminal essay, “Linguistics and Poetics” (1960), Roman Jakobson reformulated the Russian Symbolist and Formalist distinction between meter and rhythm (see Pilshchikov 2024) as the dichotomy of verse design and verse instance (Bradford 1994: 78–79). In “Meter and Performance”, Paul Kiparsky (2010) underscores the importance of Jakobson’s refinement for the analysis of performed poetry. As he reminds us, Jakobson also introduced the notion of “delivery instance” (encompassing text-setting and recitation), thereby expanding the scope of metrics from “narrow” to “broad”. Although conditioned by verse instances, permissible deliveries are not identical to them. As a matter of fact, Jakobson further complemented this triad with a fourth component,

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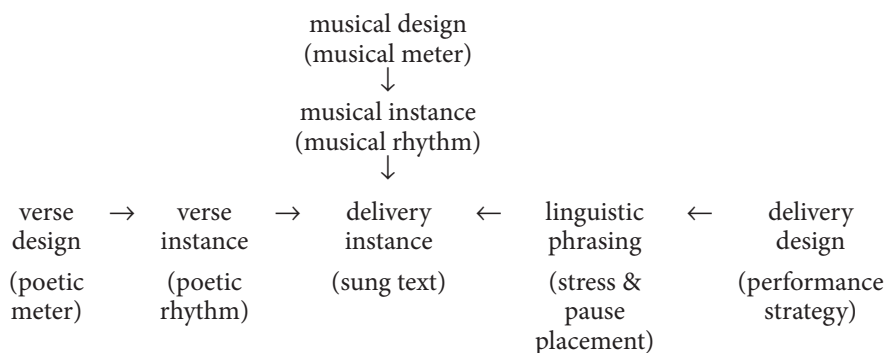
“delivery design”, which refers to performance conventions guiding the reciter to either “cling to a scanning style or tend toward prose-like prosody or freely oscillate between these two poles” (Jakobson 1960: 366). In this model, the delivery instance is shaped by both the verse instance and the delivery design:



Jakobson’s primary concern was the recitation of written poetry rather than the singing of songs. Nonetheless, his model can be effectively adapted to the analysis of sung poetry. In this case, the delivery instance is governed simultaneously by two distinct metro-rhythmical structures: the verse design and instance, and the musical design and instance (Dell, Elmedlaoui 2008: 27; Halle 2011: 187). These patterns do not necessarily coincide. As Kiparsky observes:

The composer and performer of a song constructs a match between three tiers of rhythmic structure: linguistic prominence, poetic meter, and musical rhythm. They are organized along similar principles, as hierarchies of alternating prominence [...]. But they are autonomous, in the sense that a text has an intrinsic prosodic form independently of how it is versified, a stanza has an intrinsic metrical form independently of how it is set to music, and a tune has an intrinsic musical rhythm independently of the words that may be sung to it. (2006: 7)

When discrepancies arise, the performer may shape the delivery instance in accordance with either of the competing structures, or, in Jakobson’s words, “freely oscillate between these two poles”. A tentative scheme may be outlined as follows:



This issue, already complex in itself, is often illustrated through relatively simple poetic meters, such as English trochaic tetrameter or French heptasyllabic meter. To advance the discussion, I turn instead to three Soviet-era Russophone songs, each built on a more complex verse meter that does not coincide with the song's musical meter. These examples enable us to observe how complex metrical structures interact with musical settings and how performers resolve these tensions in practice. The central question, then, is how dual-metered structures can be brought into alignment with musical patterns.

1. Hyperpaeon III (Penton III)

My first example is the song "Podmoskovnye vechera" (lyrics by Mikhail Matusovsky, 1955; music by Vasilii Solovyov-Sedoy), originally composed for the documentary *V dni Spartakiady narodov SSSR* (*At the Spartakiad of Peoples of the USSR*, 1956), in which the first two quatrains were performed by Vladimir Troshin.¹ Troshin subsequently sang it at the 6th World Festival of Youth and Students in Moscow (1957), and Van Cliburn played an instrumental version at the close of his concert at the Moscow Conservatory (1958).²

The song was therefore tied to landmark events at the height of the Khrushchev Thaw. Its title, usually translated as "Moscow Nights", more literally means "Evenings in the Moscow Suburbs" or "Evenings in the Moscow Countryside". The text was initially titled "Leningradskie vechera" ("Leningrad Evenings" / "Leningrad Nights"), but the adjective *leningrádskie* ['(evenings) in Leningrad'] is longer than *moskóvskie* ['(evenings) in Moscow']. To link the song with Moscow, the poet chose the isorhythmic adjective *podmoskóvnye* ['(evenings) near Moscow'].

The song's international popularity began after Kenny Ball and His Jazzmen released an instrumental jazz arrangement, "Midnight in Moscow" (1961).³ It became so famous that it was the only Soviet song to appear on Dmitri Nabokov's LP *Russische Lieder* (1974), compiled with his father, Vladimir Nabokov, and annotated by the latter (Efimov 2025: 107–108). Surprisingly, Nabokov père described "Evenings in the Moscow Countryside" as "a pleasant

¹ <https://youtu.be/VlOMQfVTsaw?t=2572>; also in Lebedeva, Lebedev 2023.

² <https://youtu.be/r9aKbfnMSrY&t=5840>

³ <https://youtu.be/UqHR04KZGxo>, <https://youtu.be/xEG6VFUUKTM>

romance evoking the atmosphere of dachas and evening tea on the outskirts of present-day [!] Moscow”.⁴

8 1. Не слыш - ны в са - ду да - же шо - ро - хи, всё здесь за - мер -
8 3. Что ж ты, ми - ла - я, смот - ришь ис - ко - са, низ - ко го - ло -
8 ло - до - ут - ра. Ес - ли б зна - ли вы, как мне
ву - на - кло - ня. Труд - но вы - ска - зать и не
до - ро - ги под - мос - ков - ны - е ве - че - ра.
вы - ска - зать всё, что на серд - це у ме - ня.

Source: Lebedeva, Lebedev 2023

The poem’s meter belongs to the group of syllabotonic hyperpaeonic meters, characterized by foot lengths exceeding four syllables (Kviatkovsky 1966: 205, 230–233; Kholshevnikov 1972: 36–40; 1987: 37–38; Rudnev 1989: 92–95; Gasparov 2001 [1993]: 127–128; Pilshchikov 2024: 109). All are twentieth-century experiments, with one exception: at the end of the eighteenth century the polymath Nikolai Lvov pioneered one hyperpaeon as a replica of a particular rhythmical variant of Russian epic verse (Zhirmunsky 1925: 249–253; 1966 [1925]: 229–233; Shtokmar 1941: 334–335; Bezzubov 1978; Gasparov 1978: 17, 39–40). Specifically, the meter is penton III; it is constituted by a five-syllable foot (hence “penton”) with an obligatory stress on the third syllable (thus “III”). Extensively employed in Aleksey Koltsov’s imitations of folkloric lyric poetry in the 1830s, it came to be known as *kol’tsovskij pjatislozhnik* (Koltsov’s pentasyllable). It retained folkloric and song-related associations in later poetry, including Matusovsky’s lyric (Gasparov 1999: 269–270; Zholkovskiy 2018: 184–185; 2025: 243–246, cf. 252–254).

The meter of “Podmoskovnye vechera” is two-foot penton III with a regular alternation of dactylic and masculine rhymes.⁵ Like many hyperpaeons, it

⁴ MPS 20 21988-7, BASF 0666 219. *Russische Lieder gesungen von Dmitri Nabokov*, Baß (© 1974 by MPS Records). Orchester der Volksoper Wien. Program notes for a two-side record of twelve Russian songs in Dmitri Nabokov’s rendition and all English verse translations are by Vladimir Nabokov (© 1973 by Vladimir Nabokov).

⁵ The ending, which follows the last “strong” position in verse, is called a clausula and may contain from 0 to 2 syllables. Clausulae can be rhymed or unrhymed, and they do not affect the metrical definition of a line even if they create a catalectic effect. A zero-syllable clausula

features a caesura – a compulsory word boundary between the feet, known in classical philology as diaeresis. In its first publication (Matusovsky 1957: 98), the first line was explicitly accentuated – an accent mark was printed over the second *y* in the passive participle *slyshný* ['heard'], to avoid confusion with the equally possible stress *slyshny*. The latter would yield an amphibrachic reading: "Ne slyshny v sadu || dazhe shorokhi" instead of "Ne slyshný v sadu || dazhe shorokhi" ['Are not heard in the garden || even the rustling sounds'].

In the following transcriptions, unstressed syllables are designated as 0, and stressed syllables as 1. Fully realized stresses are marked with acute accents, while rhythmically ambiguous, potentially atoned syllables are marked with grave accents.⁶ In schematic strings, the symbol "1" is *italicized* when it corresponds to a monosyllabic word and **bolded** when the syllable is in the constantly stressed position. Word boundaries are indicated as | (or | before and after clitics), and caesuras as ||:

I	1 Не слышны́ в саду́ да́же шо́рохи,	0;0 1 0 1 1 0 1 0 0
	2 Все́ здесь за́мерло до у́тра.	1 1 1 0 0 0 0 1
	3 Е́сли б зна́ли вы́, ка́к мне́ до́роги	1 0 1 0 1 1 1 1 0 0
	4 Подмо́сковные́ ве́чера.	0 0 1 0 0 0 0 1
II	1 Ре́чка двíжется и не двíжется,	1 0 1 0 0 0 0 1 0 0
	2 Вся́ из лу́нного серебра́.	1 0 1 0 0 0 0 1
	3 Пе́сня слы́шится и не слы́шится	1 0 1 0 0 0 0 1 0 0
	4 В э́ти ти́хие ве́чера.	1 0 1 0 0 0 0 1
III	1 Чтó ж ты́, ми́лая, смóтришь й́скаса,	1 1 1 0 0 1 0 1 0 0
	2 Ни́зко го́лову на́клоня́.	1 0 1 0 0 0 0 1
	3 Трудно́ вы́сказать и не вы́сказать	1 0 1 0 0 0 0 1 0 0
	4 Все́, что на́ сердце у меня́.	1 0 1 0 0 0 0 1
IV	1 А рассве́т уже́ все́ за́мётнее.	0;0 1 0 1 1 0 1 0 0
	2 Так, пожа́луйста, бу́дь добра́,	0 0 1 0 0 1 0 1
	3 Не забу́дь и ты́ э́ти ле́тние	0 0 1 0 1 1 0 1 0 0
	4 Подмо́сковные́ ве́чера.	0 0 1 0 0 0 0 1

is traditionally termed *masculine* (*m*), a monosyllabic clausula *feminine* (*F*), and a disyllabic clausula *dactylic* (*D*). Hyperdactylic clausulae (three syllables and more) are rare.

⁶ On rhythmical ambiguity, see Zhirmunsky 1925: 95–120; 1966 [1925]: 93–113; Gasparov 1974: 132–137, 148–149; Pilshchikov 2019.

Building on the statistical dichotomy suggested by Jakobson (1979a [1930]), elaborated into a trichotomy by Kiril Taranovsky (1953: 1–45; 2020 [1953]) and applied to the analysis of paeonic meters by Mihhail Lotman (1995: 310–314), we can distinguish between rhythmic tendencies, dominants, and constants and, in turn, between three types of positions in verse:

- Weak positions (W): filled by unstressed syllables or monosyllabic words;
- Strong positions (S): filled by stressed or unstressed syllables of mono- and
polysyllabic words;
- Constants (C): obligatorily filled by stressed syllables.

In Russian versification, unlike in Czech or English, the final strong position is always obligatorily stressed (exceptions are exceedingly rare); it should therefore be treated as a C rather than an S (Jakobson 1979a [1930]: 131; 1960: 361). Paeons and hyperpaeons contain more than one C.

The statistics of stresses on the odd-numbered syllables in each hemistich in this song are as follows:

	first hemistich			second hemistich		
syllables	I	III	V	I	III	V
stressed	10	16	4	6	16	0
%	62.5	100	25	37.5	100	0

I will refer to the rules governing *correspondence* between structures of different levels (e.g., poetic meter and poetic rhythm, or musical meter and musical rhythm) as *correspondence rules*, and those governing *congruence* between the structures of the same level (e.g., poetic meter and musical meter, or different types of poetic meters) as *matching rules*.

The correspondence rules for Russian syllabotonic meters, as described by Kolmogorov and Prokhorov (1968: 404–406) and Lotman (1995, 2000),⁷ may be summarized for our case as follows:

- Either
- W or S or C ← a monosyllable
- W or S ← 0
- S or C ← 1

⁷ For an Anglophone summary, see Lotman 1995: 339–349. On the principles of formulating correspondence rules, see Halle, Keyser 1971: 139–180 (Chapter 3).

or

W → 0 or a monosyllable

S → 0 or 1 (including monosyllables)

C → 1 (including monosyllables)

As in binary meters, S positions in penton III are equivalent to *syllaba anceps* (Zhirmunsky 1925: 252; 1966 [1925]: 232; Shapir 1996: 282–283). But why the caveat regarding monosyllables? In Russian literary versification, an unstressed syllable may occupy an S position, and a W position may be filled by a stressed syllable, but not within the same word. For this reason, the well-formedness of a metrical line depends on word boundaries. Configurations like “01|100” are permissible in Koltsov’s penton III, whose formula accordingly is WWCWW, and they occur as exceptions in Russian folkloric trochee and its imitations (Lotman 1995: 304; 2000: 232). However, such configurations would not produce a well-formed literary trochee, due to the “trans-accentuation ban” (Gasparov 1974: 14), also known as the Tomashevsky–Jakobson rule: “...within one word-unit a joint coincidence of the stressed syllable with the upbeat and of the unstressed syllable with the downbeat is inadmissible” (Jakobson 1979b [1955]: 168). Hence, in binary meters “a word stress can coincide with an upbeat only as far as it belongs to a monosyllabic word unit” (Jakobson 1960: 361; see Pilshchikov 2019: 62–64 for discussion).

In Matusovsky’s poem, the even-numbered positions II and IV in each hemistich are filled by unstressed syllables or monosyllabic words (whether atoned or stressed makes no difference). Consequently, its meter can, parenthesizing optional clausula elements, be described as SWCWS || SWC(WW), or line by line for the entire quatrain:

SWCWS || SWCWW

SWCWS || SWC

SWCWS || SWCWW

SWCWS || SWC

In Russian versification, (hyper)paeonic meters can be interpreted as dual-metered structures, governed concurrently by the rules of both (hyper)paeonic and binary meters (Lotman 2022). When loaded with extraschematic stresses, penton III readily “disintegrates” either into trochaic trimeter with a masculine caesura or clausula or into trochaic trimeter with a dactylic caesura or

clausula⁸ – similarly to nuclear disintegration.⁹ The stressing of the first syllable in Matusovsky’s penton (62.5%) is markedly higher than in Koltsov’s and post-Koltsovian pentons (25% and 20%, respectively, according to Bezzubov 1978: 115–117), and approximates the figures for the first syllable of well-formed trochaic tetrameters by Koltsov (62.1%), Ivan Nikitin (63.3%), and Afanasij Fet (65%) (see Taranovsky 1953: 302).

The matching rules for the hyperpaeonic and trochaic interpretations of this meter are as follows:

S	W	C	W	W		S	W	C	(W)	(W)
↑	↑	↑	↑	↑		↑	↑	↑	↑	↑
S	W	S	W	S		S	W	C	(W)	(W)
		or:	C			or:	S	W	C	

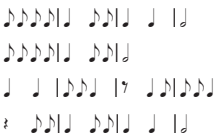
In essence, the trochaic notation indicates how the poem could be *scanned* if it were written in real trochees with pre-caesural truncation.¹⁰ The trochaic rhythmization helps to “reconcile” the poem’s rhythm with musical rhythm, but not completely: for reasons outlined above and discussed further below, not all pentonic lines are isorhythmic with trochees. As Zhirmunsky remarked of Koltsov’s pentons, “the trochaic rhythm remains nothing more than the overriding rhythmical cadence, while the only obligatory metrical features are the constant number of syllables (5) and the constant stress on the third syllable” (Zhirmunsky 1925: 253; 1966 [1925]: 232–233).

⁸ Lotman (1986: 75; 2022) termed this phenomenon “secondary meter” – a label coined in parallel to Gasparov’s concept of “secondary rhythm” (Gasparov 1974: 77–78; cf. Jakobson 1960: 362–363).

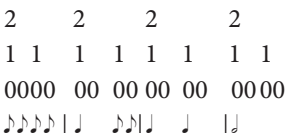
⁹ Daniil Andreev, an advocate of hyperpaeons and even hyper-hyperpaeons (Orlitsky 2018: 580–583), depicted them as “superheavy transuranic meters” (“Сверхтяжелые, трансураниевые размеры”). This line is three-foot penton III, as is the meter of his entire metapoetic *Hyperpaeon* (*Giper-peon*, 1951), from which it is taken (Plungian 2007: 3; Zholkovsky 2018: 187–188). A poet and visionary, Andreev spent ten years in Soviet prisons and labor camps, where this poem was composed. Reversing Mayakovsky’s celebrated image of writing poetry as “mining radium” from “tons of verbal ore,” Andreev likens his own “rule-breaking” poetry to plutonium, extracted from radioactive ore in a labor camp.

¹⁰ As Boris Tomashevsky noted in various contexts, scansion is “a natural operation since it is nothing but an emphatic clarification of the meter”. “This artificial scansion is not an arbitrary act, for it only demonstrates that constructional law which is invested in the lines”. “Scansion is analogous to counting aloud in learning a song or in the movement of the director’s baton” (qtd. in Lotman 1976 [1972]: 45).

For convenience, tied notes at the end of a hemistich (♪♪) are represented as rests after the bar line (♪ | ♪) – an adjustment that does not affect the matching since the onbeat and offbeat placement assigned to each syllable remains unchanged.¹¹



We can now describe the song's musical meter by aligning its musical instances with metrical grids, as proposed by Liberman (1975), developed for musicology by Lerdahl and Jackendoff (1983), and applied to text-and-tune analysis in Halle and Lerdahl 1993, Hayes and Kaun 1996, Hayes and MacEachern 1998, Kiparsky 2006, Dell and Halle 2009, Dell 2015, and Hayes and Schuh 2019. Following Liberman (1975: 276), I prefer to use numbers rather than dots, asterisks, or x's in the gridlines, but, following Fabb and Halle (2008), I begin with 0 rather than 1 as the lowest gridlevel number, thereby preserving the same lowest numerical symbol across all aligned structures. The highest level corresponds to bars and coincides with the downbeat. Double matching denotes syncopation.¹² According to Liberman (1975: 266), the *metrical grid* is "a kind of intuited structure of *time itself*, while *metrical patterns* are intuited structures of events in time". This distinction is "parallel to the distinction between meter and rhythm in music".¹³



¹¹ For ties and melismas in tune-to-text matching, see the acute remarks of Rudolf Zaripov in his pioneering study *Cybernetics and Music* (Zaripov 1971: 119–120).

¹² For the interpretation of syncopation in the framework of generative musical theory, see, e.g., Temperley 1999.

¹³ "Metrical grids are defined formally as an ordered set of ordered sets, representing the levels in a grid, of which the lowest level (the initial set) is considered *terminal*; and a function *F* that maps each nonterminal level onto a proper subset of the next level down, in such a way that the image set conforms to the ordering relations on all levels". "Metrical patterns are formally defined as trees, with uniformly binary branching, and a relation *strong/weak* defined on the two elements of each nonterminal constituent" (Liberman 1975: 302).

2 2 2
 1 1 1 1 1 1
 00 00 00 00 00 00


2 2 2 2
 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1
 00 00 00 00 00 00 00 00


2 2 2 2
 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1
 00 00 00 00 00 00 00 00


The rhythmic patterns of tune and text – musical instances and verse instances, or, in other terms, musical rhythm and verse rhythm – must be aligned. “The condition on the association of a text and a tune is that their metrical patterns be *congruent* [...]. Roughly, one tree must be superimposed on the other without any conflict of constituent structure or (metrical) node labels” (Lieberman 1975: 276). In practice, however, congruence is often only partial. This results in violations – either of metrical rules or natural language rules – which become unavoidable when the performer is compelled to align linguistic rhythm with musical rhythm.

The following presents a romanization of the first two quatrains, with the gridlevel numbers and position codes aligned to each syllable. The “correct” pentonic interpretation is supplemented by a potential trochaic interpretation, supported by the trochaic beat of the song’s music (Zholkovsky 2018: 188), even though not all poetic lines conform to it, producing “a *sui generis* counterpoint of verse rhythm and musical rhythm” (2018: 189; 2025: 252):

I	2	0	1	0	2		1	0	2	1	2
	Ne slyshný v-sadú						dázhe shórokhi,				
p:	S	W	C	W	S		S	W	C	W	W
˘t:	S	W	S	W	C		S	W	S	W	C

	2	0	1	0	2		1	0	2
	Vsjó zdés’ zámerlo						do utrá.		
p:	S	W	C	W	S		S	W	C
˘t:	S	W	S	W	C		S	W	C

	2 1 20 1		1 0 2 0 1
	Ėsli b ználi vŷ,		kák mnè dórogi
p:	S W CW S		S W C WW
*t:	S W SWC		S W S WC

	1 0 2 1 0		2 1 2
	Podmoskóvnye		vecherá.
p:	S W C WS		S WC
*t:	S W S WC		S WC

II	2 0 1 0 2		1 0 2 1 2
	Réchka dvízhetsa		i ne dvízhetsa,
p:	S W C W S		S W C WW
*t:	S W S WC		S W S WC

	2 0 1 0 2		1 0 2
	Vsjá iz lúnnogo		serebrá.
p:	SW C W S		S W C
*t:	SW S WC		S W C

	2 1 2 0 1		1 0 2 0 1
	Pésnja slýshitsa		i ne slýshitsa
p:	S W C W S		S W C WW
*t:	S W S WC		S W S WC

	1 0 2 1 0		2 1 2
	V-éti tíkhie		vecherá.
p:	SWC WS		S WC
*t:	SWS WC		S WC

I do not dwell on unstressed monosyllables in S positions at the beginning of lines, aligned with Gridlevel 2. Some, such as the negative particle *Ne* ['not'] in lines I.1 and IV.3, can be atoned; others, such as the conjunction *A* ['and'] in line IV.I, are not reduced at the beginning of a syntagma [Knjazev et al. 2007: 387–388]. More problematic are polysyllabic words extending to the fifth syllable of the pentasyllabic foot. These positions are consistently aligned with Gridlevel 2 beats, which are occupied by long – quarter or half – notes. They thus match with C positions in the potential trochee and are unequivocally stressed. No discrepancy arises when such words are disyllabic – for

example, *v-sadú* [‘in the garden’] in line I.1 – since they align with gridlines 0.2 (the potential trochee’s WC positions) and are neither trans-accentuated nor double-accentuated.

Longer words, however, present difficulties. Trisyllables such as *shórokhi* [‘rustling sounds’] in I.1 (gridlines 2.1.2), *dórogi* [‘dear’] in I.3 (2.0.1), *dvízhe[ts]a* [‘is moving’] in II.1 (2.1.2), *mílaja* [‘darling’] in III.1 (2.1.2), and *výskazat’* [‘outspeak’] in III.3 (2.0.1), or tetrasyllables *zamétn[e]e* [‘more visible’] in IV.1 (0.2.1.2) and *pozhal[us]ta* [‘please’] in IV.2 (0.1.0.2), span both the penton’s third position (C in penton, S in trochee) and its final pre-clausal position (S or W in penton, C in trochee). Aligned with two stress peaks, they become either trans-accentuated or double-accentuated, as if “musically scanned” (Zholkovsky 2018: 189; 2025: 252). Yet Russian prosody admits no secondary stress in non-compound words, so such accentuation violates the language’s basic rules.

Furthermore, forms like *zámerlo* [‘fell quiet’] in I.2 (1.0.2) are only performable if the phoneme /o/, which merges phonetically with /a/ in *unstressed* positions due to the standard Russian *akanye* (“a-ying”), is sung as a long *stressed* [á:], i.e., [zàmerlá:]. This, however, constitutes a violation of both Russian prosody (double accentuation) and morphonology, the result of *zamerlá* being the feminine and not the required neuter form of this verb. Even so, this is precisely how Solovyov-Sedoy himself performed the line.¹⁴ Troshin, whose recordings from different years survive, always sings it the same way.¹⁵ Similarly, in II.2 he sings the adjective *lúnnogo* [‘moonlight’] in the same position 1.0.2 as [lùn-navá:] instead of [lún:əvə] – a pronunciation unattested outside this song.

Attempts have been made to interpret such cases of double accentuation as trans-accentuations and to explain them as a folkloric influence (Lebedeva, Lebedev 2023). This explanation, however, is unsatisfactory, above all because similar phenomena appear in songs composed without any intention of folkloric imitation. In any case, these are minor discrepancies compared to what can occur when performing lyrics written in more complex meters.

¹⁴ <https://youtu.be/I8cyYSTQQBw?t=26>

¹⁵ Compare the 1977 Soviet Gosteleradio performance: <https://youtu.be/7F4aC2elEp0>

2. Hyper-hyperpaeon IV (Hexon IV)

The next examples come from the genre known as “bard songs” (*bardovskie pesni*), also referred to as “author’s songs” (*avtorskie pesni*), performed by their own writers, who often accompanied themselves on guitar rather than composing for professional singers (Smith 1984; Novikov 1998; Kulagin 2011; Bogomolov 2015, 2019). Among the best-known Russophone “bards” are Alexander Galich, Bulat Okudzhava, and Vladimir Vysotsky, who rose to prominence in the 1960s. Their success was preceded by earlier instances of the genre in the 1930s and 1940s, with the work of poets such as Pavel Kogan, Mikhail Ancharov, and Mikhail Lvovsky, whose songs were also performed by both professional and unprofessional singers.

My next example is Lvovsky’s 1961 song “Na Tikhoretskuju sostav otpravitsja” (“The Train Will Depart for Tikhorétskaja Station”), which was set to music by at least two different composers, most famously by Mikael Tariverdiev in 1965. The song tells the story of a girl on a train who, apparently heartbroken after a recent breakup, still remains resilient. “Tikhorétskaja” refers to the railway station of that name.

Chords: E m, A m, B7sus, E m, E m, A m, B7sus, E m, A m, F#m7(b5), B7, C, C, A m, A m, A m, B7, E m, A m, B7sus, E m, B7.

Lyrics: На Ти-хо-рец-ку-ю сос-тав от-пра-вит-ся, Од-на во-ко-шеч-ку гля-жу не груст-на-я, ва-гон-чик тро-нет-ся, пер-рон ос-та-нет-ся. И толь-ко ка-вру-ке ар-буз-на-я. Сте-на кир-пич-на-я, ча-сы вок-заль-ны-е, Ну что, сдв-чон-ко-ю та-ко-ю ста-нет-ся? пла-точ-ки бе-лы-е, пла-точ-ки бе-лы-е, пла-точ-ки ва-гон-чик тро-нет-ся, ва-гон-чик тро-нет-ся, ва-гон-чик бе-лы-е, гла-за пе- тро-нет-ся, пер-рон ос- чаль-ны-е. та-нет-ся.

Source: sheetsmusic.top

Lvovsky's song frequently appeared in anthologies of Russian "bard" songs and, until the late 1970s, also mistakenly circulated in unauthorized collections of Vysotsky's songs and poems (cf. Smith 1977: 71). The error arose because Vysotsky – a renowned songwriter and performer, a leading actor in the neo-avant-garde Taganka Theatre, and arguably the most recognizable figure of the late Soviet era – enjoyed performing this song.

Lvovsky first incorporated the piece into his 1961 play *Drug detstva* (*A Lifelong Friend*), with music composed by Tariverdiev. Its popularity, however, skyrocketed much later, following its inclusion in Eldar Rjazanov's 1975 comedy *Ironija sud'by, ili S legkim parom!* (*The Irony of Fate, or Enjoy Your Bath!*), which went on to become a New Year's Eve classic and has been hailed as "the most famous and popular movie in Soviet culture since World War Two" (MacFadyen 2003: 221). The film is particularly noted for its erudite and sophisticated soundtrack, composed of recited and sung poems (Gushchin 2024). In it, Polish actress Barbara Brylska played the female lead, with her singing voice supplied by Alla Pugachova, Russia's most celebrated pop star of the 1970s and 1980s.

This song is relevant to the present discussion because it displays different placements of the caesura in its verse and its music. For simplicity, I disregard the line between the third and final lines of each stanza, which invariably repeats (verbally, rhythmically, and musically) the first hemistich of the next line. I therefore treat the stanzas as quatrains, consistent with how they are usually presented in printed versions of the poem (e.g., Dunaev 1985: 203). The second stanza, regrettably, is omitted in the film version.

The poem employs a far rarer hyperpaemonic meter: hexon IV, defined by a six-syllable foot whose fourth syllable is obligatorily stressed.

I	1	На Тихоре́цкую со́став отпра́вится.	0 0 0 1 0 0 0 1 0 1 0 0
	2	Ваго́нчик троне́тся, перро́н оста́нется.	0 1 0 1 0 0 0 1 0 1 0 0
	3	Стена́ кирпи́чная, часы́ вокза́льные, <i>Платочки́ белые, платочки́ белые</i>	0 1 0 1 0 0 0 1 0 1 0 0
	4	Плато́чки бе́лые, глаза́ печа́льные.	0 1 0 1 0 0 0 1 0 1 0 0
II	1	Одна́ в око́шечко гляжу́ не гру́стно я,	0 1 0 1 0 0 0 1 0 1 0 1
	2	И то́лько ко́рочка в руке́ арбу́зная.	0 1 0 1 0 0 0 1 0 1 0 0
	3	Ну что́ с дево́нкою тако́ю ста́нется?	0 1 0 1 0 0 0 1 0 1 0 0
	4	<i>Вагончик тронется, вагончик тронется,</i> Ваго́нчик троне́тся, перро́н оста́нется.	0 1 0 1 0 0 0 1 0 1 0 0
III	1	Начне́т выпы́тывать купе́ кура́щее	0 1 0 1 0 0 0 1 0 1 0 0
	2	Про моё́ про́шлое и насто́ящее.	0 0 1 1 0 0 0 0 0 1 0 0

3	Наврú с трй кóроба – пúсть удивлúются.	01 1 1	0 0	1 0	0 1 0 0
	С кем распрóщалась я, с кем распрóщалась я				
4	С кэм распрóщалась я, вác не касáется.	1 0 0 1	0 1	1 0	0 1 0 0
IV	Открóет дúшу мнè матрóс в тельнúшечке,	0 1 0 1	0 1	0 1	0 1 0 0
	Кàк одинóко жítь емú беднúжечке.	1 0 0 1	0 1	0 1	0 1 0 0
	Сойдёт на стáнции, и не оглúнется,	0 1 0 1	0 0	0 0	0 1 0 0
	Вагончик трóнется, вагончик трóнется,				
4	Вагóнчик трóнется, а óн остáнется.	0 1 0 1	0 0	0 1	0 1 0 0

As with most hyperpaeons, hexon IV has a caesura and tends to disintegrate into a simpler, binary meter – this time, iamb (compare Korchagin 2021: 335). The statistics of stresses on the even-numbered syllables in each hemistich in this song are presented with the indicators for position VI counted twice (with and without monosyllables):

	first hemistich			second hemistich		
syllables	II	IV	VI	II	IV	VI
stressed	12	16	3 / 0	12	16	1 / 0
%	75	100	18.75 / 0	75	100	6.25 / 0

In this case, as in the previous example (*mutatis mutandis*), odd-numbered positions I, III, and V in each hemistich are filled by unstressed syllables or monosyllabic words, with one exception – the rhythmically ambiguous possessive pronoun *mojò* [‘my’] in the first hemistich of line III.2: “Pro *mojò* *próshloje*” [‘about my past’].¹⁶ The same applies to position VI, where stressed syllables occur only in monosyllabic words. The poem’s meter is, accordingly, WSWCWW || WSWCWW.

The matching rules for the hyperpaeonic and iambic interpretations of this meter are as follows:

W	S	W	C	W	W		W	S	W	C	W	W
↑	↑	↑	↑	↑	↑		↑	↑	↑	↑	↑	↑
W	S	W	S	W	S		W	S	W	C	W	W
or: W							or: S W C					

¹⁶ On disyllabic possessive and personal pronouns of the “01” accentual type in SW positions in Russian verse, see Taranovsky 1953: 18–19; 2020 [1953]: 137; Jakobson 1979b [1955]: 168; 1979c: 582–584; Pilshchikov 2019: 62, 64–65.

2 2 2 2
 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1
 00 00 00 00 00 00 00 00
 ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪

And for line 3:

2 2 2 2
 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1
 00 00 00 00 00 00 00 00
 ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪

I give here a romanization of the first and the third quatrain (in the movie, the third immediately follows the first), with grid numbers and position codes:

I	0 1 0 2 0 1	0 2	0 2 0 1
	Na Tikhoretskuju	sostáv	otprávit'sa.
p:	W S WC WW	W S	W C WW
'i:	W S WS WS	W S	W C WW
	0 1 0 2 0 1	0 2	0 2 0 1
	Vagónchik trónetsa,	perrón	ostánetsa.
p:	WS W C WW	W S	W C WW
'i:	WS W S WS	W S	W C WW
	0 1 0 2 0 1	0 1	0 2 0 1
	Stená kirpíchnaja,	chasý	vokzál'nyje
p:	WSW C WW	WS ()	W C WW
'i:	WSW S WS	WS ()	W C WW
	0 1 0 2 0 1	0 2	0 2 0 1
	Platóchki bélyje,	glazá	pechál'nyje.
p:	WS W CWW	WS	W C WW
'i:	WS W SWS	WS	W C WW
III	0 1 0 2 0 1	0 2	0 2 0 1
	Nachnjót vypýtyvat'	kupé	kurjáshcheje
p:	W S W CWW	WS	W C WW
'i:	W S W SWS	WS	W C WW

	0	1 0	2	0 1		0	2 0 2	0 1	
	Pro mojò pròshloje					i nastojáshcheje.			
p:	W	SW	C	WW		W	S W C	WW	
ˈi:	W	SW	S	W S		W	S WC	WW	
	0	1	0	2 0 1		0	1 0	2 0 1	
	Navrú s tri kóroba,					púst' udivljájutsa			
p:	W	S	W	CWW		W	S W	CW W	
ˈi:	W	S	W	S W S		W	S W	CW W	
	0	1	0	2 0 1		0	2 0 2 0 1		
	S kém rasproshchálas' já,					vás ne kasáetsa.			
p:	W	S	W	CW W		W	S WCWW		
ˈi:	W	S	W	SW S		W	S WCWW		

In line 3 of each stanza, the absence of a word boundary after the eighth syllable coincides with the absence of a pause at the matching beat:

0 1|0 1 0 0 || 0 1 0 1 0 0
 0.1.0.2.0.1 || 0.1.0.2.0.1

In all other lines, however, a performer is tempted into linguistically unconventional intraverbal enjambments, as in line III.2: “Pro mojò pròshloje | i na|stojáshcheje” [‘About my past | and pre|sent’]. This can be realized either with a pause after [na-] or with an unnatural semi-stressed longer [a:] that “disguises” the pause. The latter is how Pugachova performs the line, while simultaneously smoothing out the stress on *mojò* [‘my’] in the same verse:¹⁷

		2			2	2			
	1	1	1		1	1	1	1	
0	0 0	0	0 0	0	0 0	0 0	0	0 0	
ˈ	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	
Pro <i>mojò</i> pròshloje					i-nâ-sto-jáshcheje.				
W	SW	C	WW		W	S W C	WW,		

¹⁷ <https://youtu.be/5VfKTZ-W83U>. A recording of her actual performance of this song, made behind the screen, is also available: https://youtu.be/ZOAPs5W_LUw

0 10 20 10 2 1 20 1

0 10 20 10 2 0 2 0 1

7 ♪ ♪|♪|♪|♪|♪|♪| ♪| ♪|♪|♪|

$\begin{array}{ccccccc} & & & 2 & & 2 & & 2 \\ & & 1 & 1 & 1 & & 1 & & 1 \\ 0 & 00 & 00 & 00 & & 00 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 00 & 00 \\ \text{,} & \text{♩} & \text{♩} & \text{♩} & | & \text{♩} & \text{♩} & \text{♩} & | & \text{♩} & \text{♩} \\ \text{Pro } \textit{moj\grave{o}} & \text{pr\acute{o}shloje} & & & & \hat{\text{ı}} & \text{na-sto-j\acute{a}shcheje.} \\ \text{W} & \text{S W} & \text{C} & \text{WW} & || & \text{W} & \text{S} & \text{W C} & & \text{WW,} \end{array}$

010 2 10 2 10 201



0 10 20 10 2 0 2 0 1

7

¹⁸ Vysotsky introduces his performance with the remark, “Это не моя песня, но она хорошая очень” [‘It’s not my song, but a really good one’]: <https://youtu.be/CaJf-rMZtKk>

Characteristically, in the last line of the same quatrain, where both performers use the same rhythmical modification, Pugachova has no difficulty inserting a pause after the non-clitical monosyllabic personal pronoun *vás* [‘you’] in that position:

				2					2					2					
		1		1	1				1	1	1	1							
	0	0	0	00	00				00	0	0	00	00						
˘	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪			♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪					
S	kém	rasproshch	álás’	jà,					vás	ne	ka-sáetsa.								
W	S	W	CW	W					W	S	W	CWW							

[‘Who I said farewell to || does not concern you.’]

In this way, in a dual-metered structure, the stricter meter fits within the freer one. This allows us to treat a bimetrical line as governed by a single verse design with three types of syllables, avoiding duplication of the initial element of the scheme and the simultaneous appearance of two verse designs. At the same time, musical instances do not always align with verse instances. In such cases, the performer must adapt the linguistic material to either the musical or the verse instance. Most often, the rhythm of the language naturally conforms to the verse instance, but some singers choose to bend prosodic norms in order to follow the accompaniment more closely.

3. Segmented Dolnik within Loose Taktovik

M. L. Gasparov (1974: 308) noted that “each stricter meter on the steps of this staircase is inevitably an individual rhythm of a freer meter”. In terms of metrical hierarchy, this means that “if a line fits more than one meter, preference is given to the meter with less variation (*v*) in the length of inter-ictic intervals (*i*)” (Pilshchikov 2024: 108): Some freer meters may belong to a different metrical type or versification system than their isorhythmical stricter counterpart – for example, paeonic versus binary (see above), tonic (accentual) versus syllabotonic (see Lotman 1986), or accentual meters with longer versus shorter permissible variable intervals (Pilszczikow 2024: 71–73). In such situations, the governing principles of both systems operate simultaneously, and the two meters jointly shape the rhythm (Lotman 2022). This has been described as the “matryoshka” principle: one meter is contained within another, like a smaller doll nested inside a larger one.

In addition, all Russian syllabotonic and tonic meters alike allow for the skipping of schematic stresses, the addition of extra-schematic stresses, and – in logaoedic and accentual verse – the variation of the syllabic length of inter-ictic intervals (Pilshchikov 2022; Liapin, Pilshchikov 2025). These factors contribute to the diversity of poetic rhythm. Unlike traditional syllabotonic meters, whose metrical schemes are fixed and known in advance, many accentual meters are experimental and may not be fully conceptualized even by their authors. In such cases, “meter does not precede the text but constitutes its immanent property” (Lotman 2008: 33; 2024: 95). Identifying the meter of such a text requires analyzing the realized rhythm (verse instances) to establish its verse design – the pattern of constant, strong, and weak positions.

With this framework in place, I turn to a non-syllabotonic poem, crafted in a meter without precedent in earlier Russian verse, whether written or sung: Bulat Okudzhava's “Anton Pavlovich Chekhov once made the observation (that a smart person loves to learn, and a fool loves to teach)” (1982). Sardonic and satirical, it depicts flocks of fools headed by a leader of perhaps even greater foolishness. Although the title is not Okudzhava's, the song is conventionally known as “Pesnja o durakakh” [‘Song about Fools’], echoing Okudzhava's earlier 1961 piece “Pesenka o durakakh” / “Pesenka pro durakov” [‘Little Song about Fools’].

« АНТОН ПАЛЫЧ ЧЕХОВ ОДНАЖДЫ ЗАМЕТИЛ... »

Из кинофильма «Из жизни начальника уголовного розыска»

Свободно



Ан - тон Па - лыч Че - хов од - наж - ды за -



- ме - тил, что ум - ный лю - бит у - чить - ся, а ду - ра - к у -



- чить. Сколь - ких ду - ра - ков в сво - ей жиз - ни я



встре - тил, мне дав - но по - ра у - же ор - ден по - лу.



- чить. Ду - ра - ки // все! Ах, дет - ски - е сны мо - и,



ка - ка - я о - шиб - ка, в ка - ких об - ла - ках я по



глу - пос - ти ви - тал! У при - ро - ды на ус - тах ко -



- вар - на - я у - лыб - ка, ви - ди - мо, че -



Source: Okudzhava 1989: 202–203

Okudzhava is perhaps the most revered poet among the Russophone “bards”. He was the first bard to be honored with a personal volume in the prestigious *Biblioteka poeta* book series, dedicated to publishing poetic classics (see Okudzhava 2001). To appeal once more to Vladimir Nabokov’s authority, it is worth recalling that Okudzhava was the sole Soviet author whose poem Nabokov ever translated into English (“A Sentimental Ballad”, 1966; see Shvabrin 2019: 323–329).

Let us now turn to the distribution of stresses in the poem. Zero unstressed intervals between two fully stressed syllables are indicated by limmas (^). Syllables on downbeats are marked in **bold**. The syllables corresponding to the first gridlevel-1 onbeat in every hemistich are underlined. Positions preceding the first and following the last downbeat are enclosed in parentheses;¹⁹ any left unfilled are marked as “(-)”. Other empty (skipped) positions, as well as unbracketed positions filled by two syllables, are shown in frames.

¹⁹ Technically, the unaccented syllables at the end of the first hemistich and at the beginning of the second hemistich are instances of post- and pre-caesural accretion and truncation. In non-isosyllabic caesural verse, however, their functions are analogous to those of clausulae and anacruses. The role of the caesura in Okudzhava’s variations of syllabotonic meters has been examined by Kirill Korchagin (2021: 288, 335, 346–347, 350–351, 446–447; 2022: 42–46).

- I ₁ Антoн ^ Пáлыч Чéхов || oднáжды зaмéтил,
 (-) 0 1|10| 1 (0) || (0) 1 □ 0| 0 1(0)
₂ что ўмный лóбит уч́иться, || а дура́к уч́ить.
 (0) !1 0|1|0|0| 1 (0) || (-) 0! 0 1| 0 1(-)
₃ Ско́льких дурако́в в своéй || ж́изни я встрéтил!
 (-) 1 0|0 0 1|(0 1) || (-) 1 □ 0| 1|1(0)
₄ Мнé давнó порá ужé || oрдeн пoлуч́ить.
 (-) 1| 0 1|0 1|(0 1) || (-) 1 0| 0 0 1(-)
- II ₁ Дураки́ oбoжáют || coби́раться в стáю.
 (-) 0 0 1|0|0| 1 (0) || (-) 0 0 1 0|1(0)
₂ Впeред́и ^ глáвный || во всéй красé.
 (-) 0 0 1|□ 1 (0) || (0) !1| □ 0 1(-)
₃ В дeтствe я вéрил, || что oднáжды встáну,
 (-) 1 0|1|□ 1 (0) || (-) 0! 0 1 0|1(0)
₄ а дурако́в нéту: || улeтéли всé!
 (0) !0 0 1|□ 1 (0) || (-) 0 0 1 0|1(-)
- III ₁ Àх, дeтские сны́ мой – || кaкáя oш́ибкa,
 (1) |1 □ 0| 1|(0 1) || (0) 1 □ 0| 0 1(0)
₂ в кaќих oблaкáх я || пo глúпoсти витáл!
 (0) 1| □ 0 0 1|(1) || (0) !1 0 0| 0 1(-)
₃ У пpи́роды на устáх || кoвáрная улы́бка...
 (-) 0! 0 1 0| 0!(0 1) || (0) 1 0 0| 0 1(0)
₄ В́идимo, чeгó-тo || я нe paccчítал.
 (-) 1 0 0|0 1 (0) || (-) 1| 0| 0 0 1(-)
- IV ₁ А ўмный в oдинóчeствe || гул́яет кpугáми,
 (0) !1 0|0 0 1 (0 0) || (0) 1 □ 0| 0 1(0)
₂ oн цéнит oдинóчeствo || пpeв́ышe всeгó.
 (1) |1 0|0 0 1 (0 0) || (0) 1 □ 0| 0 1(-)
₃ И eгó тaк пpóстo || взýть гóлыми рукáми,
 (-) 0! 0 1|1| 1 (0) || (1) |1 0 0| 0 1(0)
₄ Скóро их пoв́ылoвят || всéх дo oднoгó.
 (-) 1 0|1|0 1 (0 0) || (-) 1| 0! 0 0 1(-)
- V ₁ Кoгдá их всéх пoв́ылoвят, || нacтúпит эпóхa,
 (0) 1| 1|1|0 1 (0 0) || (0) 1 □ 0| 0 1(0)
₂ кoтóрую нe в́ыдумaть || и нe oписáть.
 (0) 1 0 0|0! 1 (0 0) || (-) 0! 0! 0 0 1(-)

3 С умным хлопотно, || с дураком ^ плохо.

(-) 1 0|0| 1 (0 0) || (-) 0 0 1| 1(0)

4 Нужно что-то среднее, || да где ж его взять?

(-) 1 0|1 0| 1 (0 0) || (-) 0! 1| 0 1|1(-)

VI 1 Дураком быть выгодно, || да очень не хочется.

(-) 0 0 1|1| 1 (0 0) || (0) 1! 0| 0!1(00)

2 Умным очень хочется, || да кончится битьём...

(-) 1 0|1 0| 1 (0 0) || (0) 1! 0 0| 0 1(-)

3 У природы на устах || коварные пророчества.

(-) 0! 0 1 0| 0!(0 1) || (0) 1 0 0| 0 1(00)

4 Но может быть, когда-нибудь || к среднему придём.

(0) 1 0!1|0 1 (0 0) || (-) 1 0 0| 0 1(-)

The poem consists of six quatrains, but in the song it is realized as two main quatrains (A) and a chorus (B). This structure is repeated twice, forming two AAB hyperstrophes:

Text stanzaics: AAA AAA

Song stanzaics: AAB AAB

What follows is a rhythmical transcription of the musical instances in the main quatrains. A musical phrase corresponding to a poetic line may begin with an upbeat (*Auftakt*). In such cases, my transcription shows that the preceding line ends with a rest.

I



IV



II



V



A crotchet (quarter note) may be subdivided either into two quavers (eighths notes) or a quaver triplet . For purposes of tune-to-text congruence, a triplet

can be treated as equivalent to a quaver followed by two semiquavers (♪♪♪), which equally match the poetic text.

The clausulae may be masculine (*m*: ♩), feminine (*F*: ♩ ♩ or ♩ ♩ ♩), or dactylic (*D*: ♩ ♩ ♩, see below). As the poem is cross-rhymed, the actual variations are limited to *FmFm* and *DmDm* sequences.

While the main quatrains are sung in D major, the chorus is set to a different melody in the relative H minor; nevertheless, the meter and rhythmic patterns remain unchanged:

III

♪ | ♩ ♩ ♩ | ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ | ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩
 ♩ | ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩
 | ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩
 | ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩

VI

| ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩
 | ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩
 | ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩
 ♩ | ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩ ♩

Alexander Zholkovsky observes that the song about fools pairs a complicated textual pattern with a simpler musical one, often producing “a reaccentuation of words, clearly discernible in the author’s performance”.²⁰ The “reaccentuation” in delivery instances referred to here is a consequence of “trans-accentuation” in verse instances: a shift of stress from one syllable of a word to another within the same word, in contradiction to standard Russian prosody. Such shifts are sometimes tolerated in folklore, partly owing to historical accentuation changes, but they are never employed in literary poetry or non-folkloric singing.

Music, verse, and language diverge in Okudzhava’s song, forcing the performer into an uneasy choice of which norm to set aside. In his own performance, Okudzhava renders the verse rhythm accurately, adapting it to musical rhythm, but, when necessary, disregards orthoepic norms – just as Zholkovsky has pointed out. I will examine these cases below and show that the author’s delivery conveys the verse rhythm and meter, but does not exhaust the range of possible performances.

In the scheme, where position codes are aligned with gridlines, the positions between an anacrusis (*an*) and the pre-caesural positions (*pc*), as well as those between the post-caesural position (*ac*) and the clausula (*cl*), are numbered I to V in both hemistichs. Parentheses designate optional elements; for example, the last constant plus clausula C(W)(W) can produce three types of

²⁰ “...переакцентуация слов, хорошо слышимая в авторском исполнении” (Zholkovsky 2021: 272; 2025: 280).

clausulae: dactylic (...100), feminine (...10), or masculine (...1). Stress statistics are calculated under two conditions:

- (I) with monosyllables ($I = 1$) vs. without monosyllables ($I = 0$)²¹ and
- (II) accounting for reaccentuations (01 = 10) vs. not accounting for them (01 = 01).

In addition, the number of stressed monosyllables, as well as instances of reaccentuation and double accentuation, is tallied for each position (see the next page).

The performed text’s meter is, then,

(W)C(W)S(W)(W)CW(W) || (W)C(W)S(W)C(W)(W).²²

Excluding clausulae, anacruses, and pre- and post-caesural accretions, the actual configurations observed in the poem are as follows:

first hemistich	second hemistich
CWSWWC (2)	–
CWSWC (16)	CWSWC (15)
CWSC (3)	CWSC (1)
CSWC (2)	CSWC (7)
CSC (1)	CSC (1)

If reaccentuations are disregarded, certain I, III, and V positions that are partially filled with 0s must be relabeled as S. In addition, position III of the second hemistich, filled with 0s in $\frac{4}{5}$ of cases, may be reassigned as W, provided the surrounding W positions are skipped. Finally, configurations of “0 0 1” at the absolute beginning of a line must be reinterpreted as anacruses:

(W) C (W) S (W)(W) C (W)(W) || (W) C (W) S (W) C (W)(W)
↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓
(W) S (W) S (W)(W) S W W || W S W S W C (W)(W)
or: W W S or: S – W – C

As a result, the “meter of the printed poem” (i.e., the verse-meter formula as recognized independently of music) can be defined in two ways: either as

²¹ In the last two lines, $I = 1$ for C and S, and $I = 0$ for W.
²² Correcting here what I previously suggested in Pilszczikow 2024: 73.

gridlines		3					3					3				3		
		2		2			2	2				2		2		2	2	
	1	1	1	1	1		1	1	1		1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
	0 0	0 0	0 0	0 0	0	0	0 0	0 0	0 0		0 0	0 0	0 0	0 0	0 0	0 0	0 0	0 0
syllables	(W)	C	(W)	S	(W)	(W)	C	W	(W)		(W)	C	(W)	S	(W)	C	(W)	(W)
positions	<i>an</i>	I	II	III	IV		V	<i>pc</i>			<i>ac</i>	I	II	III	IV	V	<i>cl</i>	
filled	9	24	21	24	20	2	24	24	15		12	24	16	24	22	24	12	2
%	37.5	100	87.5	100	83.3	8.3	100	100	62.5		50	100	66.7	100	91.7	100	50	8.3
stressed:																		
<i>l</i> = 1	2	–	2	16	2	–	22	1	–		1	17	1	–	–	24	–	–
%	22.2	–	9.5	66.7	10	–	91.7	4.2	–		8.3	70.8		–	–	100	–	–
str. mono.	2	0	1	4	2	0	1	1	0		1	3	1	0	0	2	0	0
<i>l</i> = 0	0	16	1	12	0	0	21	0	5		0	14	0	5	1	22	0	0
%	0	66.7	4.8	50	0	0	8.8	0	66.7		0	58.3	0	20.8	4.5	91.7	0	0
01 = 01	–	16	1	–	–	–	22	–	–		–	17	–	5	1	–	–	0
%	–	66.7	4.8	–	–	–	91.7	–	–		–	70.8	–	20.8	4.5	–	–	0
re-/double	0	8	1	0	0		2	0	0		0	7	0	1	1	0	0	0
01 = 10	0	24	0	16	0	0	24	0	5		0	24	0	6	0	24	0	0
%	0	100	0	66.7	0	0	100	0	66.7		0	100	0	25	0	100	0	0

loose "segmented" 6/5-ictic dolnik, with variable clausulae and anacrusis in both hemistichs and the possibility of replacing one – but not both – 3-ictic hemistich by a 2-ictic hemistich; or as loosened 2+2-ictic taktovik (Pilszczikow 2024: 71–72). Dolnik (Dk) and taktovik (Tk) are accentual meters in which the inter-ictic interval is variable: one to two syllables in dolnik and one to three syllables in taktovik (Gasparov 1974: 220–351). The looseness of both patterns in the song about fools arises from the presence of syllables that violate one or both of the two tentative schemes: more than two unstressed syllables between ictuses is inadmissible in dolnik, more than three in taktovik, and fewer than one in either.

According to Gasparov (1974: 309), the Tk2 rhythmic forms 101, 1001, 10001, and 10101 (all present in Okudzhava's song) can be interpreted as SWS, SWWS, and SW×WS, where "×" denotes an *anceps* – a position that can be filled by either a stressed or an unstressed syllable. In Okudzhava's taktovik, as performed by the author himself, downbeats are consistently stressed, so Gasparov's SW×WS pattern resolves into CWSWC.

As in paeons, which subsume binary meters, taktovik and dolnik combine in a dual-metered structure, with taktovik as the primary meter and dolnik the secondary (or vice versa, depending on how we interpret primacy). This dual structure is reinforced by reaccentuations (stress shifts), which tend to appear precisely on the downbeats – that is, on metrical positions C. I present the most striking cases where the delivery design shapes performance, bringing out the persistence of this composite structure.

3.1. Stanza I

In Okudzhava's 1984 concert performance,²³ the very first word – Chekhov's given name *Antón* – is reaccentuated in the highly unnatural form "Ànton". The rounding of the unstressed [o], which gives the impression of word-stress, is preserved, producing an effect of double accentuation (Zholkovsky 2021: 272–273; 2025: 281–282):

²³ At Aleksandr Ivanov's TV show *Vokrug smekha* (*Around Laughter*): An Evening of Satire and Humor at the Ostankino Concert Studio, episode 23 (1984). <https://youtu.be/jfMnddyoXs8>, <https://youtu.be/ibvRr8azSqk?t=2168>

3 3 3 3
 2 2 2 2 2 2 2 2
 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1
 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0
 ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪
 Ànton Pálych Chékh- -ov || odnázhdý zamé- -til
 C W SW C W || W C(W)S W C W
 ['Anton Pavlovich Chekhov || once made the observation...']

If begun with an upbeat, line I.1 can also be sung without a stress shift as

3 3 3 3
 2 2 2 2 2 2 2 2
 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1
 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0
 ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪
 Antón Pálych Chékh- -ov || odnázhdý zamé- -til
 W C SW C W || W C(W)S W C W

I will later refer to such delivery in actor Leonid Filatov's performance of this song – in contrast to the author, the actor follows vernacular and literary prosody.

A telling example is line I.3, as it was originally published (Okudzhava 1982: 73; 1989: 202): "Skól'kikh durakóv v svo-jéj zhízni ja vstrétil!" ['How many fools I've met in my life!']. This scans as a perfect verse line if the caesura breaks the strong syntactic link:

3 3 3 3
 2 2 2 2 2 2 2 2
 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1
 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0
 ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪
 Skól'kikh durakóv v svo-jéj || zhíz- -ni ja vstré- -til!
 C W SW C W W || C(W)S W C W

Preserving the natural flow of the phrase requires avoiding a break between the possessive determiner and the noun: "...v svo-jéj || zhízni..." ['in my || life']. This, however, leads to trans-accentuation in the verse instance and either reaccentuation or atonement in performance. Okudzhava opts for the latter, singing the line to match the tune's rhythm:

²⁴ My earlier, incorrect count, reported in Zholkovsky 2021: 280 n. 7 and reprinted in Zholkovsky 2025: 280 n. 2, was 81% (39 of 48) – *mea culpa*. The article Pilszczikow 2024: 74 reports 32 of 48 based on a different interpretation of the anacrusis in line II.4.

00111 (2)
 11101 (1)
 01011 (1)
 01101 (1)
 00001 (1)

What is more, the homogeneity of the lines increases in an undulating pattern from stanza to stanza: 5 pentasyllabic inter-C intervals in stanzas I, III, and V; 3 or 4 in stanza II;²⁵ 6 in stanza IV; and 7 of 8 in stanza VI – forming a wave-like sequence of 5–3–5–6–5–7:

I (0)5(1) (1)4(1)	IV (1)5(2) (1)4(1)
(1)6(1) (0)5(0)	(1)5(2) (1)4(0)
(0)5(2) (0)4(1)	(0)5(1) (1)5(1)
(0)5(2) (0)5(0)	(0)5(2) (0)5(0)
II (0)6(1) (0)5(1)	V (1)5(2) (1)4(1)
(0)4(1) (1)3(0)	(1)5(2) (0)5(0)
(0)4(1) (0)5(1)	(0)3(2) (0)4(1)
(1)4(1) (0)5(0)	(0)5(2) (0)5(0)
III (1)4(2) (1)4(1)	VI (0)5(2) (1)4(2)
(1)4(1) (1)5(0)	(0)5(2) (1)5(0)
(0)5(2) (1)5(1)	(0)5(2) (1)5(2)
(0)5(1) (0)5(0)	(1)5(2) (0)5(0)

3.2. Stanza II

In line II.1: “*Durakí obozhájut sobirátsa v stáju*” [‘Fools adore gathering in a flock’], the noun *durakí* [‘fools’] can be either reaccentuated or atoned to avoid a disyllabic anacrusis unsupported by the musical rhythm. Okudzhava prefers reaccentuation (*dúraki* instead of *durakí*), which may also be interpreted as double accentuation (*dúraki*) – a prosodic configuration impossible in a non-compound Russian word. To mitigate the effect of this prosodic adjustment, the singer lengthens the first vowel without actually stressing it (in Russian, vowel length strictly correlates with stress) and weakens the expiratory force of stress on the second vowel:

²⁵ See the previous footnote.

3		3		3		3	
2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2
1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
00	00	000	0	00	0	0000	000000
♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪
Dŭ-	-ra-kì	obozhá-	-jut		sòbi-	-rá-tsa v stá-	-ju.
C	W	S	WW	C	W		CW S W C W

In the second hemistich of line II.1, the verb *sobirá*[ts]a ['gather together'] is double-accentuated: an extra stress is added to the first syllable of the hemistich. The reduction of [o] to [ə] is preserved, and its rounding is not restored. Since a reduced mid-central vowel cannot be prolonged in Russian, Okudzhava's performance produces an unusual stressed schwa: [səbiràtsə].

A similar effect occurs in line II.3, where the conjunction *chto* ['that'] acquires a weak stress in the same position, although in standard diction it should be atoned to prevent confusion with its stressed homonym *chtó* ['what']:

3		3		3		3	
2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2
1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
00	00	0000	00	00	000000	000000	000000
♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪
V dét-	-stve jà	vé-	-ril		chtò	odnázhdý vstá-	-nu,
C	W	S(W)	C	W		CW	S W C W

['In my childhood, I believed || that one day I would wake up...']

Yet in the same way, the verb *uletéli* ['(they) have flown away'], which occupies positions CWS (gridlines 3.1.2.1) in the next line (II.4), is double-accentuated, with an illicit additional stress on the prefix *u-* (*ùletéli*):

3		3		3		3	
2	2	2	2	2	2	2	2
1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
00	00	0000	00	00	0000	0000	0000
♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪
a durakóv	né-	-tu		ù-	-le-	-té-li	vsé!
W	CW	S (W)	C	W		C	W S W C

['...and no more fools remain – || they've all flown away!']

3.3. Stanzas III–VI

Extra accents also appear on the conjunctions *i* [‘and’] and *da* [‘but’] in stanza V, lines 2 and 4, where they fall on the first C positions in the second hemistich, aligned with the downbeat:

3		3		3		3
2	2	2	2	2	2	2
1	1	1	1	1	1	1
00	00	00	00	0000	0000	00000000
♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪

ko-tó-ru-ju ne vý- -dumat’ || í ne o-pi- -sát’.

W C W S W C W W || C W S W C

[‘...which no one can imagine || and no one can describe.’]

3		3		3		3
2	2	2	2	2	2	2
1	1	1	1	1	1	1
00	00	0000	0000	0000	0000	00000000
♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪

Núzhno chtó-to sréd- -ne-je || dà gde zh je-gò vzját’.

C W S W C WW || C W S W C

[‘We need some middle ground, || but where on earth to find it?’]

The conjunction *da* [‘but’] in line V.4 is performed differently from its occurrence in the opening lines of the last stanza (VI.1–2), where it falls twice on W positions in the second hemistich, aligned with the upbeat:

3		3		3		3
2	2	2	2	2	2	2
1	1	1	1	1	1	1
00	00	00	00	0000	0000	000000
♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪

Dû- -ra-kóm být vý-godno || da ó- -chen’ ne khó-chetsa.

C W S W C W W || W C S W C W W

[‘It pays to be a fool, || but one truly doesn’t want to.’]

3 3 3 3
 2 2 2 2 2 2 2
 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1
 00 0 0 0 0 00 0 0 000 0 00 0 0 00 00 00 00 000000
 ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪
 Ūmnym ó-chen' khó-chetsa || da kónchi-tsa bit'jóm.
 C W S W C W W || W C W S W C
 ['It's tempting to be smart, || but it ends in blows.']

To a non-native ear this may seem a minor difference, yet in Russian the unstressed *da*, meaning 'and' or 'but', is prosodically and semantically distinct from the stressed *dá*, meaning 'yes'. In V.4, therefore, the phrase *da gde* ['but where'] can only be accentuated as *da gdé*, not *dà gde* – the latter, however, is exactly the way Okudzhava performs it.

A relatively minor issue concerns the form *jego* (pronounced [jivo]) in "da gde zh *jego* *vziat*" ['but where on earth']. The possessive pronoun *jegò* ['his; its'] – phonetically and etymologically identical to the genitive/accusative of the personal pronoun *jego* ['his; him; its, it'] – is among the few Russian pronouns that can be atoned with relatively little awkwardness. Tellingly, the only indisputable example of trans-accentuation in Pushkin's iambs is "Ja predlagáju výpit' v *jegò* pámjat'" ['I suggest we should drink to his memory'] (Shengeli 1921: 26; Tomashevsky 1923: 55; Brjusov 1924: 39; Taranovsky 1953: 18; 2020 [1953]: 137; Kolmogorov, Prokhorov 1968: 422; Jakobson 1979c: 584). Pushkin treated *jego* ['his'] as rhythmically ambiguous, or "metrically neutral" (Taranovsky [1953]: 137), as though unstressed.²⁶ In Pushkin's line, as Jakobson observed,

[the] phrase-accent of the noun actually absorbs the final stress of the antecedent pronoun: the relative breath-force and voice-loudness gets lost, but the rounding of [o] still signals that the syllable is under word-stress. When connecting this stressed syllable with the upbeat and the preceding, unstressed syllable of the same word with the downbeat, the poet commits a rare deviation from the metrical canon. (Jakobson 1979b [1955]: 168)

Therefore, the atonement of this form or the admissibility of its reaccentuation has never been a norm for either Pushkin's or our contemporaries. In the discussion of this example, Maksim Shapir (2019 [2005]: 125) justly noted that if Pushkin had considered it regularly unstressed or atoned, there would have been many

²⁶ "метрички индифферентне" (Taranovsky 1953: 19).

examples of this kind in his poetry, rather than only one (compare Pilshchikov 2019: 64). Even so, the third-person pronouns *jegó* ['his, its; him, it'] and *jejó* ['her, its, it'] more easily slip into SW positions in verse than other disyllables.

In the entire song, permeated with double accentuation, only two cases of intraverbal reaccentuation (stress inversion) occur: *Anton* (I.1) and *jegó* (V.4). Okudzhava's rhythm, therefore, performs a balancing act on the edge between the admissible and the inadmissible, in keeping with the piece's "poetics of understatement" (as Zholkovsky aptly subtitled his article on this song).

A mismatch between the poetic and musical rhythm is clearly audible in the equirhythmic lines III.3 and VI.3, realizations of the same line pattern that diverge only in clausula: feminine in III.3, dactylic in VI.3. This similarity is not unusual for a chorus, though the refrain here is variable:

3		3		3		3
2	2	2	2	2	2	2
1	1	1	1	1	1	1
00	0000	00	000000	00	00	000000
♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪
Ů	pri-ró-	-dyná	ustàkh		ko-várna-ja	u- -lýb- -ka.
C	W	S	W	C	W	S
[‘Nature wears upon her lips a cunning smile.’]						

3	1	2	1	3	1	2	1	3	1	2	1
♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪
Ů	pri-ró-	-dyná	ustàkh		ko-várny-je	pro- -ró-	-chestva.				
C	W	S	W	C	W	S	W	C	W	W	
[‘Nature wears upon her lips cunning prophecies.’]											

To adapt the poetic rhythm to musical rhythm, Okudzhava places the proclitical preposition *u* ['at; in one's possession'] on the first downbeat. As a result, both the first and the last downbeats of the first hemistich are occupied by prepositions. The performer sidesteps stress on *u* at the beginning of the line by lengthening its vowel, yet, contrary to Russian speech norms, he cannot help but accentuate the preposition *na* ['on'] in *na ustàkh* ['on her lips'] (CWW, gridlines 3.1.2).

The oscillation between two contradictory poles described in the song finds a counterpoint in the oscillation between two contradictory patterns: musical rhythm and language rhythm. The song brings itself to a close with an expression of unfulfillable desire for an unattainable compromise – fittingly, free of any trans-accentuation in the final line:

1 3 1 2 1 3 2 1 3 1 2 1 3
 ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪
 No mózhet býť kogdá- -ni-bud' || k srédnemu pri-djó̇m.
 W C W S W C W W || C W S W C
 ['But, perhaps, one day || we'll reach a middle ground.']

3.4. Okudzhava's vs. Filatov's Performances

The peculiarities described above cannot be dismissed as accidental features of a single performance. Okudzhava's more intimate renderings of the song about fools – for instance, on Eldar Rjazanov's talk show *Kinopanorama*²⁷ or at the poet's home in Peredelikno²⁸ (both 1983) – display the same accentuation oddities as his 1984 concert. Yet, Okudzhava's delivery is not the only possible way to sing this song.

Okudzhava composed "Anton Pavlovich Chekhov..." in 1982 for a little-known film, in which Leonid Filatov, another Taganka actor and poet, performed it.²⁹ Okudzhava himself praised Filatov's version as remarkable,³⁰ but one can immediately hear that Filatov's rendition avoids any accentual anomalies. In full conformity with Russian orthoepy and everyday speech norms, he consistently places the standard stress on the onbeat by shifting the preceding syllables onto the upbeat. Thus, unlike Okudzhava, he performs the opening line as Zholkovsky notes (2021: 280 n. 9; 2025: 281–282 n. 2):

1 3 2 1 3 2 1 3 2 1 3 2
 ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ ♪ ˘
 Antón Pálych Chékh- -ov || odnázhdy zamé- -til
 W C SW C W || W C(W)S W C W
 ['Anton Pavlovich Chekhov || once made the observation...']

In V.4, Filatov moves *da* to the upbeat and vocalizes the particle *zhe* in place of Okudzhava's apocopic *zh* in "*da gde zh jeho vziat*", effectively turning the

²⁷ <https://youtu.be/TuRAhT3mVAs>

²⁸ <https://youtu.be/GH1mBi4tLMc>. Okudzhava's former home in Peredelikno near Moscow is now the Okudzhava Memorial Museum.

²⁹ <https://youtu.be/mbPW9n54s0>

³⁰ <https://youtu.be/ibvRr8azSqk?t=2194>

phrase into “*da gdé zhe jegó vziát*”.³¹ Notably, however, he atones *jego* just as Okudzhava does:

3	1	2	1	3	1	2	1	3	1	2	1	3
♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪	♪
Núzhno chtó-to srédneje						da gdé zhe je-gò vziát.						
C	W	S	W	C	WW		W	C	W	S	W	C

[‘We need middle ground, || but where on earth to find it?’]

Alongside this, the *dolnik/taktovik* is leveling into a binary rhythm, isometric to trochaic heptameter with a masculine clausula (T7*m*). Okudzhava’s original text already contained three such lines – isometric to trochaic heptameter and matching the basic musical rhythm | ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ | (T7*m*) in VI.2, | ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ | (T7*F*) in III.3, and | ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ ♪ | ♪ | (T7*D*) in VI.3. Filatov pushes this tendency further: a fourth line in his performance is leveled out to this binary pattern.

Overall, where the poet-singer (Okudzhava) aligns himself with the music, even at the cost of distorting his own text, the actor-singer (Filatov) upholds linguistic norms, even at the cost of altering the melody. Filatov – a skilled parodist and a poet in his own right, though less significant than Vysotsky – provides another case, alongside Vysotsky’s, where the actor ultimately prevails over the poet and the singer. Consequently, the peculiarities in Okudzhava’s performance are not unavoidable but stem from his chosen delivery design (performer’s manner): a scansion of the musical rhythm that permits words to be double-accentuated, atoned, or reaccentuated.

Conclusion

This study set out to extend Roman Jakobson’s concept of “broad metrics” to sung poetry by adding a further dyad – musical design and instance (musical meter and rhythm) – to his model of verse design/instance and delivery design/instance. Drawing also on Mihhail Lotman’s concept of secondary meter, I examined how dual-metered verse structures interact with music, showing how delivery strategies condition rhythms that may oscillate between multiple meters.

³¹ *Zh(e)* is an emphatic particle with a strengthening function. In interrogatives it imparts an intensifying effect, here rendered as “(where) *on earth*...?” to capture its force in idiomatic English.

Both verse instance (verse rhythm) and musical instance (musical rhythm) are structural patterns and should not themselves be identified with delivery instances. Only in the sung line – delivery instance proper – do actual words emerge. Verse instance is an individual arrangement of syllables, stresses, and so on, within which every lexical item can in principle be replaced by another, or even by quasi-words such as *ta-TA-ta TA-ta-ta TA-ta*.

Just as verse instance (poetic rhythm) corresponds to verse design (poetic meter) in accordance with specific correspondence rules, so too does musical instance (musical rhythm): it corresponds to musical design (musical meter) by its own correspondence rules. A delivery instance (the sung text) is subject to the simultaneous governance of both verse and music. When the two instances match, the situation is straightforward. The more revealing cases, however, are those where they diverge, forcing the performer to choose between two non-coinciding scansion: to scan the music or to scan the text. That choice, I argue, is conditioned by what I, following Jakobson, refer to as “delivery design”.

Jakobson described a related phenomenon – the tension between poetic rhythm and ordinary speech rhythm – citing Gerard Manley Hopkins, whom he called “an outstanding searcher in the science of poetic language” (Jakobson 1960: 358):

The tension between the ictus and the usual word stress is inherent in th[e]s[e] line[s] independently of [their] different implementations by various actors and readers. As Hopkins observes, [...] “two rhythms are in some manner running at once”. (Ibid.: 366)

An analogous tension arises between poetic and musical rhythm, and it, too, admits different resolutions. In the performances analyzed here, professional musicians – composers and singers – tend to subordinate the language to the musical rhythm. Actors, by contrast, even when songwriters and performers themselves, are trained to prioritize linguistic self-expression, so they depart from the musical rhythm to preserve the prosody of ordinary language.

From this perspective, mismatching is the rule rather than the exception, while matching appears only as a special case in which mismatch is minimized. Complete alignment is rare, if not impossible. Musical verse – whether song lyrics, opera arias, or other genres – should therefore be understood as a class of poetic systems governed by more than one metrical structure. And when

it comes to complex meters, the interaction with music may involve multiple concurrent systems rather than just two.³²

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³² This article is a fundamentally revised and substantially expanded version of a paper I presented twice: as a talk at *Popular Voices* – the fifth iteration of the *Plotting Poetry* convention, held at the Estonian Literary Museum (Tartu, July 4–6, 2022), – and a keynote lecture at the international online conference *Wokół (teorii) wiersza / Around (the Theory of) Verse*, co-hosted by the Pedagogical University of Kraków and the University of Warsaw (March 30–31, 2023). I am grateful to the participants in both venues for their insightful discussions, and I owe particular thanks to the editors and reviewers of the latter conference's proceedings, in which an earlier version of my article appeared in Polish (Pilszczikow 2024).

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